

Phishing attacks concealed in Google cloud services

Check Point researchers have discovered a new cybercrime trend wherein hackers are exploiting Google Cloud Platform (GCP) to conduct phishing attacks. Researchers warn that the new attacks are far more difficult for users to identify as phishing.

Researchers explain that hackers are using the popular cloud storage service to disguise their malicious activities. Hackers are also succeeding in going undetected by the red flag labels that usually warn users about suspicious websites or domains.

Demonstrating the new cybercrime trend, researchers say that they have come across a PDF file that was uploaded to Google Drive. The file contained a link to a phishing page. Hackers prompt users to enter their Office 365 credentials or organisation email details.

Once a user enters the credentials, they are directed to a PDF report published by a globally known firm. Since the hack is hosted on Google's cloud platform, users are unaware that this is a phishing scam.



Phishing page is hosted on Google Cloud Storage, making it difficult for users to detect (Pixabay)

To stay protected, users should be more cautious of look-alike domains. They should look out for easy-to-miss spelling errors in the domain and website names. Also, they should not download any file sent by an unknown sender.

Update your Chrome, Safari now to protect your data from hackers

The Indian Computer Emergency Response Team (CERT-In) has discovered multiple vulnerabilities in Google Chrome and Apple Safari browsers. The vulnerabilities could allow remote attackers to gain access to users' devices and sensitive data. The agency has advised users to update to the latest version of Chrome and Safari.

According to the CERT-In, all Google Chrome versions older than 84.0.4147.89 have been affected by the security loophole. The agency has rated the severity rating of the issue as 'high.' For Apple users, all Safari versions older than 13.1.2 are at high risk.

The CERT-In says that the vulnerabilities in Google Chrome could allow a remote attacker to gain access to sensitive information of a user. The attacker could also exploit the vulnerabilities to launch Denial of Service (DoS) attacks on a targeted system. For Apple, the agency says that the vulnerabilities in Safari could enable remote attackers to conduct cross-site scripting attacks.

Google users can download or update to the latest version (84.0.4147.89) of Chrome. Apple has also begun rolling out the Safari version 13.1.2.

AI can now predict which planetary systems will survive

Artificial intelligence (AI) today can do a number of things, from playing music to making paintings, just like humans do. Now, AI has achieved another feat. It can predict which planetary systems will collapse and which will survive in the future.

A NASA and Princeton University astrophysicist has taught an AI to run simulations for the path a planetary system will take for over billions of years to predict if it will remain stable



AI can now predict which planetary systems will collapse and which will survive in the future (Credit: Pixabay)

for the period of a star's lifecycle.

"Separating the stable from the unstable configurations turns out to be a fascinating and brutally hard problem," says Daniel Tamayo, a NASA Hubble Fellow-

ship Programme Sagan Fellow in astrophysical sciences at Princeton.

To make sure a planetary system is stable, astronomers need to calculate motions of multiple interacting planets over billions of years and check each possible configuration for stability. Modern astronomers still have to 'brute-force' the calculation, which takes hours to complete.

Tamayo took a different approach to this problem. He accelerated this process by combining simplified models of planets' dynamical interactions with machine learning (ML) methods. This allowed the elimination of huge swaths of unstable orbital configurations quickly—calculations that would have taken tens of thousands of hours can now be done in minutes.

The AI model called SPOCK (Stability of Planetary Orbital Configurations Klassifier) determines the long-term stability of planetary configurations about 100,000 times faster than the previous approach, which in turn determines if the planetary system will 'live long and prosper.'